

BEYOND THEATRICAL MARKETING: Play Banns in the Records of Kent, Sussex, and Lincolnshire

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A succinct assessment of medieval plays' banns — the public announcements that preceded a given play performance, often proclaimed in towns beyond the performance site — recently appeared as part of Linda Ehrens Voigts's editorial apparatus for her edition of a newly-discovered fifteenth-century physician's advertisement. To locate her discovery with respect to a broader genre, Voigts first refers to the 'widespread' general use of banns throughout late-medieval England, with a range of public functions extending well beyond advertisement:

Banns were public proclamations. The verb *bannan* (Old and Middle English) meant, in the narrow sense, to summon by public proclamation, and in a broader sense to make a public announcement. The term survives in reference to marriage banns ... More important to the text at hand was the more common phrase used with general public announcements, 'to cry the banns'. Numerous citations in the *Middle English Dictionary*, including many from the fifteenth century, locate this crying at a public marketplace or at a fair. Banns were cried by a crier (ME 'criour'), a term used not only for town criers, but also for those who were paid to make announcements on behalf of a private person.¹

With that definition in place, Voigts looks to the extant texts of play-banns for cognate examples of what one might expect to find in the text of a fifteenth-century advertisement — since fifteenth-century play-banns have thus far been consistently interpreted, to use Bruce Moore's phrase, as 'medieval theatrical marketing'.² Before Voigts's discovery, medieval drama seemed to provide the only examples in which extant English bann-texts explicitly sought to advertise to potential customers: 'A medieval European banns', according to Douglas Sugano, 'took three basic and public forms: a lord's proclamation, a marriage announcement, or an advertisement of a play performance'.³

References in the *MED* support Sugano's first two uses of *ban*, a noun usually appearing (as Voigts notes) in constructions with *crien*, with many

citations spanning the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, attesting to banns' utility in communicating a lord's decree to his vassals (to rally support, for instance, for a military campaign) and in officially publicising impending local marriages.⁴ According to the *MED*, the use of *ban* in connection with drama began later, in the mid-fifteenth century, with only four citations — none of which, on their own, mention explicitly that the banns' purpose was to *advertise* the play.⁵ Two citations come from glossary entries, which only specify that 'banns' are 'of a pley'; one of them glosses the term as a *preludium*, which suggests that the glossators might have been referring to introductory prologues, rather than self-contained proclamations advertising a play in advance.⁶

The remaining two citations come from financial records, both at Lydd.⁷ In one, from 1468/9, the Lydd Chamberlains pay 3s 4d to bann-criers — that is, to bann-criers visiting from Stone, a small town about ten miles to their northwest ('Item paid to þe pleyars of stone Crying þe Banez here, iij. s. iiij. d.'), leaving the modern archivist wondering why the chamberlains of one town would pay a fee for another town's advertising.⁸ The other, in 1466/7, shows the Lydd Chamberlains putting money toward their own criers' expenses ('Item paid in Exspences of oure Bane cryares of oure play, xxd.') — only half the amount they gave to the criers from Stone.⁹ The second example is a very unusual case, as I will show below, in that it records money spent by a town on its own bann-criers at all. By far, the majority of the financial records of expenditures associated with the word *banns*, or with any proclamation cried in connection with a play, present a model in which bann-criers receive compensation from the towns they visit, not from their own. Still, the editorial apparatus for *REED: Sussex*, *REED: Lincolnshire*, and *REED: Kent, Diocese of Canterbury* — the volumes in which the bulk of those bann-records now appear — consistently interpret banns as 'advertisements', sent by local parishes 'throughout the countryside' to 'promote' plays being performed nearby.¹⁰

The extant texts of play-banns do not reliably link the *REED* bann-records to theatrical marketing. Following Lawrence Clopper's work on the extant texts of sixteenth-century Chester banns, Moore has shown convincingly that these 'ceremonial' texts had no real function as advertisement or marketing — he presents that reading in contrast to the 'southern banns' for *The Castle of Perseverance*, the *Croxton Play of the Sacrament*, and the *N. Town Plays*.¹¹ The present study is the first half of a two-part project on the banns: I will make the difficult case *contra* Moore,

in the upcoming companion piece to this article, that the practical public function of the *Castle* and *Croxton* proclamation texts cannot be reduced to the fleeting publicity plugs in their penultimate stanzas. Regardless, the link from the banns of the records to the ‘banns’ of *Castle*, *Croxton*, and *N.Town* is rather weak to start with — none of those three pre-show proclamations explicitly refer to themselves as ‘banns’, nor are they titled as such (nor does Voigts’s medical advertisement use the term), which surely explains the paucity of references to play-banns in the *MED*.¹²

Present-day common sense dictates, simply, that a proclamation summarising an upcoming play, delivered through multiple locations well in advance of that play, is most likely an attempt to entice a broad base of potential attendees to the play.¹³ If the extant textual and archival evidence from early banns in Lincolnshire, Sussex, and eastern Kent chafes against that common-sense assumption — and, as I will show below, most of it does — then that misalignment, as counterintuitive as it feels, offers an opportunity for theatre historians to re-examine our understanding of how early economies produced drama. The economic exchanges recorded in these records make clear, as I will demonstrate, that while some banns may have had a small positive impact on show attendance, audience-building advertisement was unlikely to have been the primary purpose behind their proclamation. I argue, instead, that the banns visible in the *REED* volumes are best understood as *fundraising appeals*, ceremoniously and publicly delivered to those donors who were likely to help cover production costs, or to otherwise provide financial support to the subsequent plays or their parishes. In the give-and-take of that fundraising system, plays emerge less as capitalist ventures (in which, through marketing and advertisement, productions compete to win potential audiences) than as a large-scale and long-term series of collaborations, manifesting and maintaining a network of mutual good will.

Banns were serious business. In 1498, the New Romney chamberlains recorded a local legal decision, regarding delinquent bann-criers for their town’s play:

Quo die viz. in festo annunciacionis Beate Marie Anno regni Regis supradicti terciodecimo quod proclamatores bannorum ludi de Romene Communarij eiusdem ville adinuicem contardabant, quod ijdem proclamatores important banna saltem billas eorundem citra ffestum sancti Georgij proximo post datam presencium, & illo deficiente incarceretur xl dayes ...

On which day, namely, on the Feast of the Annunciation to the Blessed Mary [March 25] in the thirteenth year of the reign of the abovesaid king [Henry VII, i.e. 1498] that the proclaimers of the banns of the play of Romney, commoners of the same town, were both mutually tardy; that these same proclaimers should convey the banns, or at least *billas* of the same, before the feast of Saint George [April 23] next, after the date of the present [decision], & if anyone fails in that, he shall be imprisoned for forty days ...¹⁴

Tardiness for the proclamation of New Romney's banns had already resulted in civic admonition threatening legal action; failure to deliver the banns was to be punishable by significant jail time. It is the aim of this study to understand how and why the work of banns could be so important.

Above, I have left the Anglo-Latin *billas* untranslated. Since the court at New Romney rules that the tardy proclaimers might 'at least' (*saltem*) convey *billas* as a substitute for the banns, it follows that these *billas* likely also accomplished, if less effectively, whatever function the court felt to be most essential in the usual bann-proclamations. Abigail Ann Young glosses *billa*, in this 1498 case, as 'a handbill or placard containing an announcement, *here* one containing the banns of a play'.¹⁵ However, I am aware of no other attested Anglo-Latin or English example in which the word *bill* signifies publicly visible, written marketing or publicity before 1590 — after a century-long interval in which early modern attitudes toward the circulation of written material changed radically.¹⁶ During that century, the use of printed handbills developed 'at the forefront of media breakthroughs', in which advertisers — the most prominent being quack doctors, as M.A. Katritzky has shown — 'pioneered printing and performing techniques, their publicity and distribution networks support[ing] the earliest mass media'.¹⁷

Before those breakthroughs, Latin *billa* and English *bille* almost always occur in business, formal ceremonies, or legal actions, directed at an individual or small group: to convey a *bille* is usually to send a personal letter or to provide a financial record, a binding contract, or the official documentation — usually delivered by a formal reading aloud — of a plea, charge, bull, petition, supplication, or summons.¹⁸ These formal uses of *bille* are very common in the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, and attested throughout the *REED* volumes and the Middle English corpus.¹⁹ Before 1590, the only instances in which a *bille* appears to be a publicly posted or circulated document of any kind — a rare occurrence — is for posted *denunciations* of a person or group, in which a prankster or insurrectionist

wishes to make a public statement but to keep its source secret.²⁰ An anonymous denunciation is, of course, quite the opposite of a public advertisement for a product.

A handbill or placard only makes sense in the first place, in the New Romney case, if the essential function of New Romney's banns were to publicise a play's scheduling information. In fact, if a posted placard were among the 'early mass media' by which New Romney might publicise its production schedule, then it might for many reasons work better than a proclamation, rendering banns-as-advertisements quickly obsolete. The seriousness of forty days' imprisonment, however, seems like overkill for a job that could be accomplished in a pinch by a placard. Nor does it make sense to choose the same delinquent commoners, initially hired as criers, to be simple couriers for placards — anyone else could have done that delivery job easily, and as I will discuss below, the feasting and entertainment provided by host towns would have made the job a much-coveted one. New Romney insists upon those particular commoners who were *talented at proclaiming*, and it gives them a full month (from the Feast of the Annunciation to St. George's Day) to get their act together, suggesting that the banns usually required skill and preparation, to accomplish a task that a publicity placard could not replace.

Rather, the mass of attestations of *bille*, above, makes it likely that the New Romney legal directive '*important ... billas*' is a requirement for the proclaimers, if they fail to convey the banns normally, at least to ride out to their destinations and read an official or formal statement aloud, regarding the plays, to a specific individual or small group. That kind of pre-show ceremony does have a precedent in fifteenth-century drama: in preparation for the York Corpus Christi plays: the mayor frequently (usually annually) arranged for *billets* to be 'delyueryd furth' — a quasi-legal ceremony, not a publicity stunt, sent from the mayor by six sergeants-at-arms, to be read aloud to the officers of each guild that produced a play, who kept the *billets* as a sign of their acceptance of the charge laid on them.²¹

The York plays were performed in a large urban centre, drawing further audience from smaller satellite towns; as a result, the York guilds required support from a central political authority.²² In contrast, we know from the records that Romney bann-criers (when they weren't tardy) circulated through various locations in the Cinque Ports and their connected towns: across eastern Kent to Ivychurch, Folkestone, Dover, Hythe, Lydd, and west into Sussex, at Rye.²³ If New Romney's 1498 *billas* — or the bann

proclamations for which the *billas* are meant to stand in — sought support and approval, they sought it from surrounding towns, who had no political authority over their neighbours in the way that York's mayor had authority over the guilds. The economic and cultural networks that connected the small and mid-sized towns of eastern Kent, Sussex, and Lincolnshire had no centre. Cameron Louis's description of Sussex puts it nicely:

Considering that many of these locations were probably villages of no more than a hundred people or so, it is remarkable that so few people could have produced so much drama ... Here a community of communities or cultural neighbourhood seems to have been in operation, in which the production of drama created and reinforced a regional network and presumably overcame geographical distances as well as differences in economic status ... the town plays must have been a way of reinforcing economic and geographical bonds between communities which, while they may have been of unequal status, were not bound by traditional relationships and hierarchies.²⁴

The notion of a 'community of communities or cultural neighbourhood' seems equally applicable to the networks of towns around the Cinque Ports and the Wash. If these towns' banns sought support or approval — and it will become clear that this was indeed the serious business they were meant to accomplish, affirming relationships that *were* bound by a kind of tradition — then they sought it laterally, not hierarchically.

Bruce Moore has argued that banns, in performance, could provide highly theatricalised 'extensive entertainment' — a good explanation, I think, for the extra month of preparation allowed to the tardy New Romney criers.²⁵ Moore's readings of mimetic performance cues in the *Castle* and *Sacrament* banns, to which I will return in the second half of this study, convincingly support that hypothesis; so does a New Romney expenditure record from 1560/61, allotting 10 shillings to provide 'beardes and heares' for four bann-criers and a fool.²⁶ However, Moore proposes his 'extensive entertainment' hypothesis in the first place to explain the curious way money flows through the banns, recorded in the then-available archives of Kent or Lincolnshire, which — given the received assumption that the banns' primary function is to advertise — simply made no sense otherwise:

Freiston [sic], Donington, Leake, Boston, and Kirton are ... twenty or more miles away from Long Sutton, and obviously engaged in an advertising campaign. And yet this is an advertising venture for which they are *paid*, and paid more than players from other towns who obviously put on a performance ... The only reasonable conclusion is that the Banns also involved performance, and performance of some magnitude, to gain the payments received.²⁷

Moore reports on similar patterns of payment in the bann-records throughout Kent, especially at New Romney, and then in Lincolnshire.²⁸ The extant banns' high theatricality — for Moore, perhaps rivalling the plays themselves — is the 'only reasonable conclusion' that could explain, for Moore, *why Long Sutton would pay Freiston for the privilege of hosting advertisements for Freiston's own plays*, which, to the degree that they were successful, would draw Long Suttoners away from their hometown. Moore also suggests that the banns' theatricality might justify the effort and expense it took for Leake to advertise in Long Sutton, a town twenty-three miles away, where the criers 'could not expect to attract large numbers to their play'.²⁹

Both of those rationalisations are rather strained. In the records, banns are explicitly called proclamations *of* or *for* a 'stage pley', clearly distinguished in function (and likely in form) from the plays themselves.³⁰ And as theatrical as the banns may have been, it simply does not make economic sense that an advertising campaign whose primary purpose is to build audiences for New Romney's play should be consistently paid for — at often very high rates — by every surrounding town except New Romney. Yet that economic system, in which bann-criers draw considerable money from surrounding towns, is by far the dominant model for most attested banns between 1460 and 1560. Indeed, after Moore published his study, the release of *REED: Sussex*, *REED: Kent*, *Canterbury*, and *REED: Lincolnshire* provided new access to (at my count) at least 130 different and distinct expenditure records involving banns.³¹ Only seven of the 130 records I found refer to any cost put forward by the towns on whose behalf the banns were cried. And other than the beards and wigs from 1560/61 New Romney, those costs are minor: a few pence for travel costs (shoeing horses, watering horses, bread for feeding horses) or for the inscription or transportation of written scripts.³² The remaining expenditure accounts all record money paid to visiting bann-criers, or spent upon them, by host towns.

These accounts usually separate their bann expenditures into two categories: 'expenses' and 'reward'. 'Expenses' (or *in expensis*, or often *in vino*) cover any money spent on entertaining the criers with food and drink during their visit.³³ 'Reward' (or *in regardo*, compare Old French *regarder*) refers to a flat amount handed to the bann-criers in cash. It seems more reasonable to expect bann-criers to attract 'reward' fees than to attract audience: the bann-criers from Leake could hardly expect a significantly large crowd of excited play-goers to follow them twenty-three miles from Long Sutton, but they would have little trouble conveying cash across that distance.

The sparse wording of the expenditure records, for the most part, does not say much about what the banns were there to do, nor why they received payment. One among the 130 records does mention, in passing, that banns did announce an upcoming production: at Rye in 1530/31, ten shillings 'in mete & Wyne' are given to 'the Inhabytauntes of Ivecherch beyng here *Warnyng* to ther pley'.³⁴ Another record, at Dover in 1532/3, mentions in passing that a shilling is rendered 'vppon men of ffolston at *askyng* of there banys afore theire pley'.³⁵ Two functions for banns, *warning* and *asking*, emerge here. It is not in the records' wording, but in the sheer amount of times that 'reward' money is allocated to the bann-criers, that the banns' capacity for *asking* — at least from the perspective of the account-keepers who are the only extant witnesses to these banns in the first place — emerges as their more essential function. The banns' collection of money, then, is not an archival anomaly attached to an advertising campaign: it is standard practice; it is the archivists' primary reason for recording the banns at all; and it might, in New Romney in 1498, be adequately (but less effectively) executed by the formalised and directed appeal of a last-minute *billet*.

James Gibson, in his editorial apparatus for *REED: Kent, Canterbury*, maintains the dominant definition of play-banns as advertisement and promotion; Gibson is also, however, the only scholar so far to point out that bann-criers, having delivered their advertisements and received ample food and drink, were also '[u]sually ... rewarded with donations toward play expenses'.³⁶ Gibson absorbs those 'reward' payments into the medieval production model as it is currently understood, so that donations given to bann-criers appear to provide the producers of plays with an extra bit of help, auxiliary to their primary source of capital — start-up loans from affluent locals:

Apart from using the money collected by the bann criers in advance of the performance, the play-wardens apparently paid the majority of

expenses for rehearsals, costumes, and properties from loans that were then repaid from the play's receipts.³⁷

REED: Kent, Canterbury is especially demonstrative of the banns' capacity to garner donations: it includes, from c.1483–6, a rare play-wardens' account that describes the financial output *and intake* of the New Romney *Passion*.³⁸ The play-wardens' account, at folios 11^v–12^r, right beneath its records of New Romney's start-up loans (*accomodauerunt pecunias ... In primis*), records a series of bann-donations received from various towns and people (*[r]ecepte per Bannarios ad diuersa*):

Nomina hominum qui accomodauerunt pecunias ludo In primis viz

De wilhelmo Gregory	iijs. iiijd.
De wilhelmo Dobyll	iijs. iiijd.
De Ricardo Randislow	iijs. iiijd.
De Thoma Bursell	iijs. iiijd.
De Thoma Coupar	iijs. iiijd.
De wilhelmo Wodar	iijs. iiijd.
De wilhelmo Melhale	iijs. iiijd.
De wilhelmo Swan	iijs. iiijd.
De domino Ricardo	iijs. iiijd.

... ecepte per Bannarios ad diuersa viz.

... parochia de luecherche	iijs. iiijd.
... parochia de ffolkstone	vs.
... lla de [He] Hethe	vjs. viijd.
... lla de lydde	vjs. viijd.
De parochia de Brokeland	iijs. iijs. iiijd.
De Iohanne hamon ex dono	xijd.
De Georgio halsnoth	xvjd.
De laurencio Norkyn	xijd.
De Margareta Burston	viijd.
De Edmundo kelet	xijd.
Item receptum de Ricardo ffoldiswell	viijd. ³⁹

The play-wardens, here, do not record a *summa* (a grand total) beneath the pre-production start-up loans, which are stricken out in the manuscript; the total amount of start-up loans, if we add it up now, comes to an even £1 10s. That is no small sum: later on in the play-wardens' account, we learn that the revenue the day of the show (*recepte in die ludi*) of the New Romney *Passion* generates £4 14s 3d in *summa*.⁴⁰ As far as we know, the

production of the New Romney *Passion* only had four show days: if pre-production loans were paid back from play-day revenue, as Gibson suggests, then 31.8 percent of the play-day yield would have to be immediately subtracted and returned to the capital loaners.⁴¹

The play-wardens also neglect to include a *summa* for their bann-donations, but the total amount of bann-donations comes to £1 10s 8d. The spare eight pence may have been an unexpected afterthought, given that Richard Foldiswell's donation of 8d shares a line with Edmund Kelet's, while other donations are lineated with more care. In other words, the amount of money generated in bann-donations is strikingly similar, and probably identical, to the amount restored to the capital loaners. These bann-donations are recorded immediately below the crossed-out loans; barring Foldiswell's extra gift, the extant record of pre-show bann-donations thus appears to cease precisely when it reaches the intake necessary to cover the pre-show loans. Thus, the record strongly suggests that the banns' capacity to solicit 'rewards' was hardly auxiliary to the loans; rather, the simplest explanation here is that the play-wardens sent out banns with the express purpose of repaying those loans. The banns' pre-show solicitations of support from neighbouring towns, and from individual local donors (whose expenditures, visible here, would not be otherwise recorded in *REED*), could thus allow plays like the New Romney *Passion* — themselves costly (if potentially lucrative) parish fundraisers — to begin production in the black.

In other cases — likely smaller-scale productions than New Romney's *Passion* — bann-donations may have gone directly to the parish for which a production was raising money, by-passing the play (if there was one) altogether. In 1565/6, for instance, the St. Helen's Overseers of the Poor at Leverton record 5s 'paid & given to the reparacion of Borene church when they declared Sutton fundraise locally ahead of a *travelling* performance (as opposed to a large-scale performance like New Romney's, which could not easily travel); the churchwardens subsequently bestow the locally raised funds upon the travelling players when they arrive in town to perform. Cummings's model thus makes clear that a collection taken up for a performance did not necessarily have to take place 'during the performance itself'.⁴⁴ His intramural fundraising model, in which donations are collected locally in order to draw non-local players inward, complements the extramural bann-based model I propose here, in which donations are collected non-locally in advance of locally grown productions (which drew out both local and non-local audiences, whether

or not the productions travelled). Lincolnshire drama thus emerges from a network of small-scale fundraising and loaning, passing through multiple channels at once. In Lincolnshire as in Kent, that lateral and mutual support may indeed have had a comparably ceremonial import, as a ritual affirmation of the fraternally shared responsibility and authority that these towns held *over each other*, and of the mutual enjoyment that came from shared investment in the theatrical landscape overall. That import is suggested not only in the 1498 conveyance of *billas*, but also during Lydd's and Hythe's banns in New Romney in 1503/4 and 1504/5, respectively, two occasions when the bailiff and jurats of a town visit and proclaim the banns themselves.⁴⁵ their Bane'.⁴² After receiving a donation at Leverton, in this case, the bann-criers from Bourne shuttle their 'reward' directly to their home parish, where a fundraiser play is assumedly being held. There is a strong possibility, too, that the Bourne banns are not connected with a play at all here, but are simply a *non-dramatic* fundraising appeal, erroneously included in *REED* under the assumption that banns are always involved with dramatic productions.

More than one model for fundraising surely co-existed in Lincolnshire. James Cummings includes, as part of his 2001 doctoral dissertation at Leeds, an assessment of small-scale 'gatherings for plays' around the Wash.⁴³ In Cummings's examples, churchwardens at Sutterton and Long

Moore, writing in 1993, did not yet have access to the c.1483-6 New Romney play-wardens' account. The account's intake records solve Moore's contradictions with clear simplicity: Lydd pays money to the New Romney bann-criers not because the bann-criers have rendered them a service, but because the bann-criers are there in the first place to solicit donations. The New Romney intake of 6s 8d donation from Lydd, c.1483-6, corresponds exactly to the standard 'reward' donations, recorded by Lydd's chamberlains, given to Romney in 1479/80, 1516/17, 1525/6, and 1532/3. The fact that the New Romney play-wardens receive the full 6s 8d 'reward' into their play accounts, without any apparent deduction, rules out Moore's hypothesis that the bann-criers took a cut for themselves as though they were paid as entertainers.

The frequent donation of standard 'rewards', most often 3s 4d, 4s or even 5s, or 6s 8d (like Lydd's contribution to New Romney), also suggests that bann-criers, like modern fundraisers, sought out repeat donations from year to year from the same sources.⁴⁶ However, the lack of a *summa* in the New Romney accounts suggests that bann-donations were not always a sure thing — each loan crossed out, it seems, only as an

equivalent amount of donation came in. Records beyond New Romney confirm that no standard ‘reward’ donation between towns could be relied upon unfailingly. After 1532/3, Lydd’s ‘rewards’ to New Romney fluctuate: they give twice in 1539/40, 10s followed by 5s; then 10s in 1559/60. Hythe, which gives New Romney a solid 6s 8d in the c.1483–6 play-wardens’ accounts cited above, only gives 2s in 1497/8. Hythe can still afford to give a standard 6s 8d to bann-criers in 1508/9 — but this time they give it to bann-criers from Lydd.⁴⁷ The Sussex records tell a similar story: Rye, for instance, gives a standard 3s 4d ‘reward’ to the bann-criers of Brookland in three different years; but twice, Brookland’s bann-criers score 4s at Rye; and once they garner 5s. While the surviving records of Lincolnshire, Sussex, and eastern Kent can only offer a partial picture of the economies that supported drama, that partial picture suggests that set ‘reward’ donations were understood as a norm from which givers readily deviated — for better or worse. Had the c.1483–6 New Romney play-wardens’ *not* succeeded in reaching their bann-donation goal, their considerable capital loans would be left precariously unpaid. It is no wonder, then, that delinquent New Romney bann-criers in 1498 are threatened with forty days’ imprisonment. Interestingly, Cummings also describes a case at Long Sutton in 1565/6 in which a loan made in advance of fundraising, overseen by the churchwardens, cannot be paid back from the local ‘gathering’; the churchwardens, with some uneasiness, must pay the difference.⁴⁸

The ‘reward’ payments, deviating around a norm, go straight from one town’s chamberlains to the other town’s play-wardens; the ‘expenses’, far more erratic in their generosity, are spent on the bann-criers themselves. For instance, alongside its standard 6s 8d ‘reward’ to the New Romney criers in 1516/17, Lydd also spends 24s 3½d ‘in ‘expenses’ on the banecriers of Romeney’ — spending an exorbitant amount, likely in one night, that was comparable to the total of Romney’s pre-show loans. In the following year, New Romney goes even higher, spending the massive total of 32s 9½d (‘reward’ and ‘expenses’ lumped together) on bann-criers from Appledore, a relatively small town that could not have produced a particularly impressive drama. In 1508/9, the Hythe chamberlains provide, in some detail, an idea of the ostentation with which a town could receive another town’s bann-criers:

Item paid to the banecriours of lydde	vjs. viijd.
Item paid to Rose Galen for ale for the same banecriours	xjd.

Item paid to william hamme for ij capons & for wyne for the seid banecriours	ijjs. vjd.
Item paid to Richard Butter for a lambe for the same banecriours	xijjd.
Item paid to Clement Holwey for wyne for the same banecriours	iiijjd.
Item paid to a Coke & # to a turnebroche & a disshwassher	iiijjd.

After they receive the standard 6s 8d ‘reward’ as a donation for their show, the Lydd bann-criers also get 5s 1d worth of ale, capons, wine, a lamb, and then more wine — with a few pence even set aside for a *turnebroche* (a person hired to turn a roasting animal on a spit).⁴⁹ Mutual exchange among towns, initiated by the exchange of financial support for plays, is thus affirmed in a festive tradition that Johan Huizinga would recognise as playful potlatch, a ‘gift and counter-gift’ economy whose currency Pierre Bourdieu would identify as ‘symbolic capital’.⁵⁰

According to Bourdieu, though the gift exchanges that typify small-community economies are often apparently reciprocal (Lydd gives a 6s 8d ‘reward’ to New Romney’s bann-criers in 1479/80; New Romney gives a 6s 8d ‘reward’ to Lydd’s bann-criers in 1486/7), all such exchanges can systematically generate ‘symbolic capital’ for those participants who demonstrate, in the way that they give gifts, a practical mastery of local culture.⁵¹ Bourdieu warns against ‘naively idyllic representations of “pre-capitalist” societies’; as he explains, these exchanges of symbolic capital are *always* defined by economic interest — albeit an economic interest that present-day consumers have trouble seeing or understanding, due to our ‘unconscious acceptance’ of a restrictive capitalist definition of *economy*.⁵² With this warning in mind, it is helpful to remember that the *turnbroche* and dishwasher, who receive payment from the Hythe chamberlains during the Lydd bann-criers’ visit, are necessarily local to Hythe — as are Rose Galen, William Hamme, Richard Butter, and Clement Holwey, the hosts who supply the extensive food and drink. Similarly, when New Romney hosts the Appledore bann-criers in 1488/9, its chamberlains hand over 2s 9d of ‘expenses’ to William Dobyll, a Romney vinter.⁵³ That deal works out well for Dobyll: when the chamberlains reimburse him for the libations enjoyed by the Appledore bann-criers, they are surely paying him for wine he drew from his own stores. The festive potlatch of banns thus locks in business for Dobyll (at Romney), and for Galen, Hamme, Butter, and Holwey (at Hythe). It is surely no coincidence, then, that in the New Romney play-wardens’ intake record quoted above, William Dobyll also

appears as one of the repaid supporters who laid down a pre-show loan for the *Passion*. Dobyll is thus an *investor* in the Romney *Passion*: he puts forth a loan, is paid back in the short term by bann-donations, and — through the exchange facilitated by later banns — gains business as a local vintner.

The economic efficacy of the banns, firmly lodged in the ‘community of communities’ of the Cinque Ports, thus does not seem to depend at all on whether Dobyll or anyone else *actually attended the play*. Indeed, large-scale plays would not necessarily benefit significantly from a wholesale increase in attendance.⁵⁴ Especially given the open layout of their performance spaces, these plays seem to have collected audience revenue not from entry fees but from the solicitation of voluntary donations during and after the show.⁵⁵ A spike in the number of attendees might not ensure an equivalent spike in donations, especially since high-rollers like Dobyll could just as easily give or loan money prior to the show; to entice too many attendees, meanwhile, might result in the considerable cost of hiring extra marshals to manage the crowds.

There is little reason to assume, anyway, that any significant portion of these plays’ audiences would need to be enticed. Modern consumers of media are accustomed to an economy in which countless public utterances must compete for our attention, while multiple products compete for our patronage: advertising gurus Al Ries and Jack Trout insist that such conditions are historically unprecedented, resulting in ‘the world’s first overcommunicated society’.⁵⁶ In Louis’s ‘cultural neighborhood’, in which ‘villages of no more than a hundred people or so ... produced so much drama’, anything resembling modern ‘theatrical marketing’ or a ‘film trailer’ would be unnecessary, and certainly not worth any significant investment of time or money.⁵⁷

I do not mean to suggest that advertisement was never necessary in a medieval context; I contend only that it was not necessary for drama in the small- and mid-sized towns of late medieval Kent, Sussex, and Lincolnshire. Louis’s ‘[s]o much drama’ still amounts to only a few known performances in any given year. Distant towns would likely not provide many attendees; neighbouring towns already *did* attend each other’s productions, sometimes emptying out their own towns to do so.⁵⁸ Perhaps the banns’ capacity for ‘warnyng’ uninformed audiences might have garnered a few new attendees at a production — perhaps the non-local traders who passed through the Cinque Ports.⁵⁹ But it is otherwise hard to believe that a large-scale play project in New Romney like the *Passion* of the play-wardens accounts in 1483–6, especially one that had been produced

repeatedly in prior years (as early as 1387), would not already be generally well-known in the other four of the Cinque Ports (including Rye and Hythe), let alone in Romney's corporate limbs (including Lydd), and even in very small satellite towns (like Appledore) — well-known enough, at least, to make the considerable effort (and, following Moore, expense) of an *advertisement* redundant, rather pointless, and hardly serious enough to be enforced by the threat of incarceration.⁶⁰

William Dobyll did not have a range of concurrent urban entertainments to choose from, each competing for his attention. An active participant in the Kentish 'community of communities', he would surely attend any major event that was accessible and available. What pre-show banns needed to wheedle out of affluent men, and neighbouring towns, was not their attendance, but their financial support. To deliver that fundraising 'ask' with an impressive or expensive performance would thus be cost-effective — since a successful bann could be rewarded with higher 'rewards', and lavish 'expenses'. The capacity for banns to 'ask' more or less effectively also explains, as I will show in my next article, the shrewd strategy that shaped the *Castle of Perseverance* banns, linking them powerfully to the lost banns of the archives.

In the system of bann-donations, then, the 'community of communities' is doubly affirmed. The 'reward' reinforces inter-urban economy: towns donate to neighbours whose support they have recently received, so that the full network of play productions registers as a mutually supported and generally beneficial element of the cultural landscape of Kent, Sussex, and Lincolnshire. The 'expenses' not only ensure that business is regularly generated for affluent locals, who might thus become investors in the play, but also engage in an ostentatious potlatch, ensuring mutual good will — which is valuable in itself, but also highly economically profitable.

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NOTES

1. Linda Ehram Voigts 'Fifteenth-Century English Banns Advertising the Services of an Itinerant Doctor' in *Between Text and Patient: The Medical Enterprise in Medieval and Early Modern Europe* edited Florence Eliza Glaze and Brian K. Nance (Florence: SISMEL, Edizioni del Galluzzo, 2011) 251–3.
2. See Bruce Moore's influential 'The Banns in Medieval English Drama' *Leeds Studies in English* NS 24 (1993) 91–122, on which more below. To date, Moore's is the only sustained study of the banns of early drama.

3. Douglas Sugano *The N-Town Plays* (Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, 2007) 335. As Voigts puts it, quoting Bruce Moore at 252, 'The only group of surviving Middle English banns known to me (besides those parodied doctor's banns [in the Croxton *Play of the Sacrament*]) are those used in the later Middle Ages for what has been called "medieval theatrical marketing".'
4. MED sv *ban* n. (at definitions 1a and 1b); see also earlier examples at *bannen* v. (for which no cases are associated with drama)
5. MED sv *ban*, n. (at definition 1c).
6. MED sv *ban*, n. (at definition 1c). The prologue to *The Pride of Life* is sometimes called 'banns' by modern editors (not in the manuscript), though it quite clearly is to be delivered immediately before the first bit of dialogue, in the same location, rather than travelling well in advance of a performance. It is one among many such prologues in medieval and early modern drama that summarise the play's action, often including conventional calls for a crowd's attention; such prologues do not stand as proclamations *separate* from the play itself, and so do not fit into the 'banns' genre to which Moore, Sugano, and Voigts refer. See *Two Moral Interludes: The Pride of Life and Wisdom* edited David N. Klausner (Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, 2009) 9–12.
7. MED sv *ban*, n. (at definition 1c); REED: *Kent, Canterbury* 665.
8. REED: *Kent, Canterbury* 665. For the confusion of modern archivists, see below, and Moore 'Banns' 97.
9. REED: *Kent, Canterbury* 665.
10. See, respectively, REED: *Sussex* xlv, REED: *Lincolnshire* 425 and 431, and REED: *Kent, Canterbury* lvi.
11. Moore 'Banns' 91–4. The 'ceremonial' function of the Chester Banns is (correctly) established by Lawrence Clopper in the 1979 REED: *Chester*, from which (at Clopper lv) Moore draws the concept of 'call[ing] forth' the guilds.
12. For beautiful digital images of the Macro manuscript (Folger Shakespeare Library MS. V.a.354), and its lack of any specific reference to the proclamations as 'banns', see <luna.folger.edu> (at Digital Image File Name 31554). Nor is there any manuscript reference to 'banns' for the *vexillatores'* similar pre-play proclamation for the *Croxton Play of the Sacrament*; see *Non-Cycle Plays and The Winchester Dialogues* edited Norman Davis (Leeds Texts and Monographs; University of Leeds, 1979) at 95. Nor does Douglas Sugano record any direct manuscript reference to the N.Town proclamations as 'banns'; see Douglas Sugano *The N-Town Plays* (Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, 2007) at 435.
13. As I will explain at length in the upcoming second half of this study, while it is clear that the extant *Castle* and *Sacrament* bann-texts do include short publicity plugs directed at potential audiences, this does not seem to have been their

primary function, nor a function that they achieve very effectively or energetically. For further examples of the dominance of the idea that the extant banns *primarily* function as audience-building marketing, see Alexandra F. Johnston 'An Introduction to Medieval English Theatre' in *The Cambridge Companion to Medieval English Theatre* edited Richard Beadle and Alan J. Fletcher (Cambridge UP, second edition 2008) at 11, in which the primary purpose of theatrical banns is assumed to be 'to pique the interest of the populace in the forthcoming performance'. See also the introduction to Klausner *Castle*, at 6, which interprets banns' primary function as publicity expressly directed at potential audiences ('publicising an upcoming performance ... an invitation to attend a performance').

14. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 755. All Latin translations of *REED* material, here and below, are my own adaptations or recalibrations of the excellent translations provided in the *REED* volumes.
15. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 1510.
16. *OED* sv *bill*⁵. Young cites *OED* definition 8a in her gloss of the New Romney case, which dates the use of *bill* as 'a written or printed advertisement' as early as the fifteenth century. However, that dating seems to be erroneous, or at least to refer to a broader definition of 'advertisement' that is not relevant to our discussion here. The only *OED* citation for definition 8a provided before 1600 is from Caxton's *Chronicles of England* (the *Brut*): 'The scottes made a bylle that was fastned vpon the chirche dores of seynt petre'. In context, these are anonymous Scottish pranksters who publicly post a mocking denunciation 'in despyte of Englysshmen', choosing a medium that hides its origin (rather than promoting it) — quite the opposite of an *advertisement* in the sense of promotion or marketing (on which more below). See William Caxton *The Cronycles of Englonnd* in *Early English Books Online* (*EEBO*) <eebo.chadwyck.com> (at Bibliographic Number 9992), chapter ccxiii, document image 99 of 169.
 These earliest attested cases are also in *REED*, at *REED: Cambridge* 340, 342, 1335 and *REED: Norwich* 96, 181.
17. M.A. Katritsky, *Women, Medicine and Theatre 1500–1750* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2007) 120. Thanks to Meg Twycross for this reference.
18. *MED* sv *bille*; *OED* sv *bill*³; see also note 16.
19. Indeed, the vast majority of Young's citations of the words throughout the *REED* volume gloss *bille/billa* only as a specialised term for business transactions ('itemised statement of charges or expenses') or legally binding actions ('list of complaints or allegations ... charges certified by the presenters' signs or signatures').
20. See notes 16 and 20.

21. A charge that was revoked at least once, in 1550, when the cancellation of that year's performance necessitated that the 'common offycers of this City' should 'tayke in to theyre hands the bylletes yat was delyuerd furth' (*REED: York* 295). See also *REED: York* 14, 17, 287, 701, 703.
22. The formal reading of bann-texts aloud from a page seems, at New Romney, to be a less-desirable replacement for the usual proclamations. A later New Romney record, from 1502/3, renders a payment to a courier *pro portant vnum parcellum bannarum ludi*, suggesting, perhaps, that in the absence of a central authority the *documents themselves*, here called *parcels* (i.e. scripts or 'sides'), did not have ceremonial significance; the use of a *parcel* may suggest, however, that even non-tardy bann-proclamations did not always have to be memorised.
23. For the Romney bann-criers' presence at Ivychurch, Folkestone, Hythe, and Lydd, see the New Romney play-wardens' accounts, c.1483–6 (*REED: Kent, Canterbury* 748), as well as accounts for Hythe in *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 624 (1497/8), and for Lydd in *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 670 (1479/80), 674 (1516/17), 681 (1525/6), 687 (1532/3), 691 (1539/40), 696 (1559/60). For Dover, see *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 360 (1479/80), 447 (1547/8). For Rye, see *REED: Sussex* 70 (1503/4), 88 (1516/7), 96 (1525/6), 106 (1539/40), 117 (1559/60).
24. *REED: Sussex* xliv–xlv.
25. Moore 'Banns' 98.
26. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 791 (New Romney 1560/61).
27. Moore 'Banns' 97.
28. Moore 'Banns' 98–100.
29. Moore 'Banns' 98.
30. See, for instance, *REED: Sussex* 91 (Rye 1519/20) and *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 430 (Dover 1533/4).
31. I am grateful to the extensive indices for all the *REED* editions, which made my search for bann records possible. My search was limited, for the most part, to bann records prior to 1560. The preponderance of bann records in Sussex, Kent, and Lincolnshire is in striking contrast to the other published *REED* volumes, in which I count only 28 records involving banns in total, and none involving payments rendered by host towns to bann-criers (this does not count Diana Wyatt's unpublished work for *REED: Yorkshire, East Riding*, which will include two cases in which Beverley pays to host bann-criers from Cottingham and Riston, which I will discuss at more length in the second part of this study).
32. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 665 (1466/7, Lydd, 1s 8d); 745–50 (three expenditures, totalling 4s 10½d, in the New Romney play-wardens' accounts, c.1483–6); 757 (1502/3, New Romney, 8d); 768 (1526/7, New Romney, 5d).

33. In his discussion of play-banns around the Wash, James Cummings notices that quite a few Lincolnshire bann-records set aside money specifically for food and drink for the criers while they visit. See James Cummings 'Contextual Studies of the Dramatic Records in the Area around The Wash, c.1350-1550' (PhD thesis, University of Leeds, 2001), accessed 22 November 2014 via *White Rose eTheses Online* <etheses.whiterose.ac.uk/635/1/uk_bl_ethos_424661.pdf> at 315-8.
34. *REED: Sussex* 100 (Rye 1530/31), emphasis added. This record, interestingly, does not expressly use the words *proclaim*, *cry*, or *bann*.
35. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 429 (Dover 1532/3), emphasis added.
36. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* lxiv-lxv.
37. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* lxiv-lxv, emphasis added.
38. For a full discussion of the New Romney *Passion* and its likely staging and content, see Pamela King 'The Early English Passion Play' *Yearbook of English Studies* 43 (2013) 69-86.
39. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 748. The ellipses here represent damage to the manuscript. The Latin headings translate to 'Names of the people who lent money to the play in the first [place], as follows' and '[Received/Accepted] through banns at diverse [times], as follows'.
40. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 749.
41. See King 'Passion Play' 80.
42. *REED: Lincolnshire* 102 (Leverton, 1565/6).
43. See Cummings 'Contextual Studies' 311-15.
44. Cummings 'Contextual Studies' 312. While he maintains the standard advertising model for banns (318), Cummings also very briefly mentions the capacity of bann-criers to collect for a play (at 312), though in that case it the collection is within Sutterton for a Sutterton-produced play.
45. In both years these VIP criers are given the standard 6s 8d *reward*, but a larger-than-usual reception in *expenses*; *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 757-8.
46. Bann-payments of 3s 4d are handed over at Rye in 1493/4, 1505/6, 1520/21 (*REED: Sussex* 64, 74, 92); New Romney in 1508/9 (*REED: Kent, Canterbury* 760); Leverton in 1525/6, Wigtoft in 1525/6 (*REED: Lincolnshire* 102 and 340, in both cases to the criers from Swineshead). 4s bann-payments are handed over at New Romney in 1495/6 (*REED: Kent, Canterbury* 753); Rye in 1507/8, 1516/17, 1518/19, 1521/2, 1526/7 (*REED: Sussex* 76, 88, 91, 93, 98). 5s bann-payments are handed over at Rye in 1516/17 (*REED: Sussex* 76, 91, 93, 98); Hythe in 1508/9, Lydd in 1539/40 (*REED: Kent, Canterbury* 628, 692); Long Sutton in 1542/3, Leverton in 1565/6 (*REED: Lincolnshire* 224, 102). 6s 8d bann-payments (i.e. exactly double the 3s 4d payment) are recorded not only in

the New Romney play-wardens records c. 1483–6 (discussed at length above) but also at Rye in 1508/9, 1516/17, 1525/6, and twice in 1502/3 (*REED: Sussex* 78, 88, 96, 71); Wigtoft in 1532 (*REED: Lincolnshire* 340); Beverley in 1423/4 (see note 31); New Romney in 1493/4, Hythe in 1508/9, Lydd in 1525/6 (*REED: Kent, Canterbury* 752, 628, 681). Interestingly, standard rewards in these amounts seem also to be frequently used to compensate travelling players or minstrels directly.

47. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 628 (Hythe 1508/9).
48. Cummings 'Contextual Studies' 315–16.
49. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 674 (Lydd 1516/17); 765 (New Romney for Appledore 1517/18); 628 (Hythe 1508/9).
50. For a classic study of the community-based play of potlatch, see Johan Huizinga *Homo Ludens: A Study of the Play Element in Culture* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1939, translation 1955) 58–63. On symbolic capital, see Pierre Bourdieu *Outline of a Theory of Practice* translated Richard Nice (Cambridge UP, 1977) 171–83. The variation in *expenses* may likely be a reflection of *how many people* were received as bann-criers, rather than how much food or drink was received by any one person; either way, the wide variation suggests that bann-crying provided an opportunity for an ostentatious display to visitors of local wealth and hospitality.
51. Bourdieu *Outline* 171–83. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 670 (Lydd to New Romney, 1479/80); 750 (New Romney to Lydd).
52. Bourdieu *Outline* 177.
53. *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 751 (New Romney 1488/9) and, on Dobyll, 1357. Dobyll also received bann-criers from Wye (17 miles north of Romney) in 1491/2, for which he received a 2s 11½d payment *in expensis* (*REED: Kent, Canterbury* 752).
54. There is a strong contrast to be drawn here with Chester and York, major urban centres whose economic 'profit' from their cycles depended on drawing as many people as possible into the city to see the spectacle. While those attendees never were asked to give money to the productions proper, their presence in the urban market centres could significantly increase revenue for the cities — or, at least, policy-makers at Chester believed it could. See David Mills *Recycling the Cycle*. The same effect might happen (though on a much smaller scale) in the towns discussed here; I propose below, however, that the mutual proximity of the towns *ensured equally high attendance with or without the banns*.
55. See for instance *REED: Kent, Canterbury* 749.
56. Al Ries and Jack Trout *Positioning: The Battle for Your Mind* (New York: McGraw Hill Professional, 2000) 1.

57. *REED: Sussex* xliiv–xlv.
58. Moore 'Banns' 100.
59. See *REED: Kent, Canterbury* xiv–xvi.
60. For the dates of the *Romney Passion*, see King 'Passion'.